

Speaker 1 [00:00:03] Okay, cool. Let me get my transcript out.

Speaker 2 [00:00:08] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:00:08] So let's get started. Thank you again so much for participating in this interview. As mentioned over email and text or text for call, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships and we believe your experience and perspective would bring much this project. I know I just asked you before this by me to have like on recording, but it's it. All right. All right. If we record this interview and all, I mean using it for transcription and note taking.

Speaker 2 [00:00:34] Mm hmm.

Speaker 1 [00:00:37] So I'd just like to start off. We're going to ask my demographic questions. So how old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:44] [20-25].

Speaker 1 [00:00:45] Okay. How long have you been together with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:49] Like [6-10] months.

Speaker 1 [00:00:52] Do you have children?

Speaker 2 No

Speaker 1 who lives in the household.

Speaker 2 [00:00:59] Um. Mine.

Speaker 1 [00:01:04] Yes. As like what you would define as your household. Yes.

Speaker 2 [00:01:09] I guess I have my [name] living with me.

Speaker 1 [00:01:13] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:01:13] That's nice.

Speaker 1 [00:01:15] And what is your main source of income? And like, what is your current job?

Speaker 2 [00:01:19] So entirely unemployed. I rely upon the charity of my mentor currently.

Speaker 1 [00:01:25] nice. How would you like us to dress your partner? So, like, for [Partner's Name], like, as a girlfriend partner and those kind of things

Speaker 2 [00:01:38] surprise me. You can call her my slave If you'd like my captive, hostage. Those are all fun ones.

Speaker 1 [00:01:45] Sounds good. I'll switch it up just for you.

Speaker 2 [00:01:48] Okay. Thank you.

Speaker 1 [00:01:51] Yes, of course. Can you tell me more about your love story?

Speaker 2 [00:01:58] Did she not?

Speaker 1 [00:02:01] She did. So basically, I have to ask you to see what your perspective is. If you want, you can make it shorter than hers. She. Went to pretty big detail.

Speaker 2 [00:02:11] Okay. I started bugging her on [Social Media]. And she never told me to fuck off. So I kept doing it. And now we're here.

Speaker 1 [00:02:31] Okay, Sounds good. How would you compare the quality of your relationship slash captive compared to that of your friends relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:02:39] Higher quality. I don't think that has anything to do with the circumstances of the relationship or the fact that we're gay or anything like that, especially with the knowledge in mind that lesbian relationships are notoriously abusive. But I. I don't know. I'm a bit more strict with who I decide to get involved with compared to the other people that I surround myself with. So I feel like I'm just more inclined to have higher quality. But. You know, dating shitty men doesn't help, so. Yep.

Speaker 1 [00:03:22] May I ask how many, if any, romantic partners have you had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:03:27] [1-5] others. Okay. Oh, I was just going to say, if you're only asking about, like, well-defined relationships and not like, situationships.

Speaker 1 [00:03:38] Oh. Either one works if you want one to differentiate, differentiate and tell me like like a specific number for each. That would be great too, but.

Speaker 2 [00:03:50] I don't have a specific number for situation ships. Then them shits are a too high up. But romantic relationships definitely [1-5].

Speaker 1 [00:04:00] Okay. And how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:04:06] Um, I mean, I would consider it higher because. I don't know. The first one I got into, I wouldn't consider I want to consider other than the healthiest. This one is definitely more healthy. But. Except for the second one, which which was a straight relationship with a man overall. cursed, considering, you know, what I ended up being, he didn't like the whole gay thing. Unsurprisingly. But I don't know. The first one was with another woman. It wasn't horrible. I wasn't the best, but I was also [11-15] or [16-20]. Being young definitely doesn't help, but that sort of thing, I it was just very codependent, as all and so was the second one. I kept that going. And that's why I ended up staying with him for so long was because of the huge. Factor being codependent with one another. I wouldn't say the mine [Partner's Name] relationship is very codependent. I'd like to think that we both have separate lives for one another and we're both pretty good at keeping relationships with other people, you know, good friendships. She has good relationships with some family members, so. That helps. And obviously it's hard to be codependent when you've got states between you. But it's not impossible. However, I don't think we've achieved it. Who knows what the future holds? Yeah, yeah, yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:05:49] And for you, what makes, like, a high quality relationship or like, a low quality relationship? And why would you say so?

Speaker 2 [00:05:56] I honestly just think the ability to enjoy each other makes for the biggest factor in a high quality relationship. I see so many relationships where the people just simply do not seem to like each other. And I was in one. We [redacted] hated each other. I mean the man I was with straight up. But you honestly don't realize it sometimes when you're just forced to be around each other every day, you can manage to sit there and convince each other. And I see this a lot with my friends relationships. You can just convince yourselves that it's communication issues. You know, the reason why you just cannot seem to be on the same wavelength no matter how hard you try. But some people just simply don't get along. And that can be kind of a kick in the face when you realize it and you're in that sort of situation. But thankfully, I did. And so getting out of it, I decided, you know, I wanted to actually pursue somebody I liked. So I gave it a lot of time. When, you know, we were just getting to know each other and let that kind of develop on its own and that that happened. I don't know. That helped a lot. I'm not super concerned about, like other things, like how much time we can spend together, because I feel like if you want something to work, you will make it work. There's a reason why people were managing to, like, keep monogamous relationships back in the [Year] when, you know, all they could do was send letters between each other while one of them was out of fucking war or, you know, in the [Location]. And the other one was in [Country], in the new colonies. If you really want to, you're going to make it work. And I feel like we're pretty good at that. I never feel insecure that she doesn't like me. And I like to think that she doesn't feel super insecure, that I don't like her. Or at least if she does, it's not because I'm doing anything. And if it was, if it happened to me, I would just change would happen. I'm doing wrong. And that's another thing is just. The willingness to put effort forth. Because if you start taking each other for granted, that's when things just start to go downhill. And that's kind of what happened a lot with like my other relationships or just, you know, whatever you may call, whatever else I got involved with. You kind of got to you got to stay present and you got to stay attentive.

Speaker 1 [00:08:26] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. That makes sense.

Speaker 1 [00:08:29] Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:08:31] So would you say like, a high call relationship is something where you. And this like I like like where you generally, like like each other's company and where you like each other. Is that something that you would say? Sorry. That was a.

Speaker 2 [00:08:48] Kind of sorry. Repeat that for a second.

Speaker 1 [00:08:50] No, I'm sorry, I said kind of strangely. But like, would you say that a high quality relationship is one.

Speaker 1 [00:08:55] Where.

Speaker 1 [00:08:57] You generally enjoy each other's company and, like, enjoy each other?

Speaker 2 [00:09:01] Yeah, I would say so. I think it's the foundation of all relationships. Honestly, if you guys can't like. Sit in a room together or like on the phone together without

something like to do, like either, you know, like consuming some sort of substance because that's what a lot of my friendships in the past have been based on, just like drinking together or like doing even doing a specific activity together. And you guys can just exist around each other and enjoy existing around each other. Then how do you plan to, you know, make that work, work moving forward when say, you know, you can't do something with each other or half your time is just going to be spent existing in the same house together? You know, if you end up living together or getting married or whatever may happen in the future, at least that's how I see it. And it's done me pretty well so far. Because I would say that, like my first relationship was fairly successful. We did like each other. I was the problem there, but we were able to, you know, just sit on [Social Media] or sit in the same room together or, you know, do whatever and just have a good time being around each other and existing with one another, you know, making idle comments towards one another and enjoying just little like pleas for interaction and being happy that the other person just, you know, wanted to be there.

Speaker 1 [00:10:24] Yeah. Yeah, that's nice. And when like in this relationship currently. What would you say your relationship was like? What did you feel last? Like you generally enjoy each other's company and enjoy each other. And when would you say like you have felt like the least like that?

Speaker 2 [00:10:42] The least like that. Oh, I mean, there's, of course, always going to be things about somebody I do not like. I would say with [Partner's Name] specifically, she has a hard time being quiet. We love her to death. And it's something that I find like. I find it cute even though it like annoys the fuck out of me sometimes. But you know, like just the inability to shut the [redacted] up sometimes is definitely something that just grates on me. But it's only something that, like, grates on me, you know, where I'm just like, Oh, you know, I'm never going to lash out. I'm never going to be rude about it. And I don't even ever tell her to stop because I still enjoy having her there. But it's just like a situation where it's like, Oh, it would be nice to be silent right now, or I'm trying to think about something or think through something maybe that I'm, you know, trying to process. And it's just, you know, maybe right now I don't need to hear about, you know, the comic book story you just saw on the side of the road. But I still enjoy hearing about it because that means that she's there. And, you know, we are with each other and it's better than not having her there.

Speaker 1 [00:11:52] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. And for you, what is the most important thing in a relationship? And why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:12:01] Oh. I don't know. I guess there is no. Most important thing for me. Um. I guess the most important thing would be the ability. To, like, adapt to one another. Like I just said, like everything. Like every relationship, Whether it's a friendship, you know, a relationship with your family or a romantic relationship, it's going to come with its challenges because no two people are actually perfect for one another unless, like, it's literally a unicorn situation, Like the stars are fucking aligned. No two people are going to be 100% good for each other 100% of the time. So you need to be able to adapt to each other's idiosyncrasies that may not sync up. Like her thing where she just likes to chat all the time and just like, have idle chatter to fill the space. That's not something I'm used to. It's not something I enjoy. But am I going to get mad at her for it? Like, unless it's like a dire situation or it's like, Hey, I need some silence right now. In that case, I can always just tell her, Hey, can we just chill for a second or can I be alone? I know she would never, you know, get upset with me for that. So that's something in which, you know, it would actually cause her to need to adapt to me. And same with her. Like, I need to either adapt to that or, you know, adapt to a way to communicate to her that this is something that's important

to me. Contrary to popular belief, I do not actually think communication is the most important thing in a relationship. And I hate when people say that all the time. I feel like communication is a Band-Aid for when two people just cannot adapt to one another. [Redacted].

Speaker 1 [00:14:57] Yeah, that makes sense. And I think it's very interesting that you mentioned. that communication is not the most important thing because in my notes it actually says to specifically mentions communication and how like a lot of people say that communication is like the most important thing. So I think that's very interesting. So I would say communication. I think you touch on a little bit, but if you'd like to give more information why you think communication is maybe not the most important thing in a relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:15:24] Yeah, well, okay, so there's a difference between like conflict resolution communication and, like, being in, like, just regular old conversation. I feel like when most people think of communication, they're thinking of conflict resolution, like, Oh, you have to sit here and explain step by step why you feel this way. And then they need to validate your feeling. Like if you've ever been to therapy or relationship counseling, I feel like a lot of communication that's encouraged in relationship counseling is actually very demeaning and patronizing. I do not need to know that you accept my acceptance or you accept me feeling valued by like, Shut up. Well, like I said, I was in a relationship in which communication was literally a Band-Aid. We simply did not like each other and we did not respect each other as people. And everybody was just sitting there. And, you know, I was bringing up these issues in which it was clear that we just did not get along whatsoever. However, everybody. Hello?

Speaker 1 [00:16:44] Hello. Okay. You cut out for me?

Speaker 2 [00:16:47] Yeah. I'm sorry about that. I noticed where I leave off. Um. Okay. I'm sorry. Oh, no, it's okay. I get it. But no, I think that communication could be used as a Band-Aid. And like I was saying. There's a difference between like conflict resolution communication. If you are feeling the need to do like text book communication all the time, there is something wrong there. The communication that I like to push for people who you know. I don't know. May need a definition of communication or I feel like actually need it. Are people who just like. I don't know. Hmm. So when I think of communication, I, I try not to think of conflict resolution because that makes me want to vom. But I think more of like, you know, just as an example, say you're about to have sex with somebody and this is a good time in which communication will come into play. Sitting there telling them, Oh, I don't actually like to be touched there because it makes me feel uncomfortable. Or, you know, actually, I like doing this because, you know, this is something I've done in the past. And the way that this partner did it was actually really good for me. So maybe we could try it like that or like, Hey, if you're going to try something new with them, maybe like something non-sexual, just like an activity, it's like, Oh, this may make me nervous. Because, you know, it may remind me of like this experience I've had in the past. I feel like that stays in communication, but everybody always thinks of conflict resolution, so I've just poisoned the word. I'm so tired of everybody sitting there saying, Oh, you're husband. Thinks you're an actual child and won't let you even go and buy groceries on your own. You should communicate to him that this makes you feel bad. He doesn't care. You can't communicate someone into caring about you. But so many people are trying. So my advice is to stop. And honestly, if your relation if you and them just work together and like each other and actually are dedicated to, you know, making each day the highest quality that you can for one another, you know, within a reasonable amount with what you are reasonably able to do, you actually will find yourself communicating that much. You won't find yourself, you

know, basically begging them to respect you as a person and to do things that you like. If [Name] tells me offhandedly that she really likes the snack. Chances are it will buy it for her. Next time I'm at the store, she will not have to sit there and communicate with me and tell me, hey, I would appreciate it if you put more effort into the relationship because I will just want to. It's fun for me. So that's why I don't like the term communication. I feel like it has its place, but it's way overused anymore.

Speaker 1 [00:20:04] Well, I think you made some really good points that really got me thinking. But I think you really hit the nail, honestly. Like, I totally agree. I honestly, I really agree with what you're saying. Like, if. If what you're if your relationship is not working in the sense of like. This is what I'm getting from like what you're saying. But basically, like, if you're if your relationship is like if you communicate every single thing in a relationship, it's not just a communication anymore. It's like. Like how compatible you are, is that kind of thing.

Speaker 2 [00:20:36] Yeah. Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:20:37] I totally agree on that for sure. Um, so this is a different, a new topic, but for you, what is love?

Speaker 2 [00:20:50] Oh, um, I think it's a lot of different things. Um, I think it changes depending on the situation. I think it can be, you know. I mean, like romantic love specifically or just in general. Um.

Speaker 1 [00:21:12] Whatever you think. Whatever you think is more applicable to what we're talking about here. But I think in general, romantic love is what we're talking about.

Speaker 2 [00:21:23] I think love is basically effort. And that's more or less the cornerstone of it. I think it's just the desire to want to make, you know, the experience that, you know, the object of your affection. I feel like it's the desire to make their experience the best it can be within your capabilities, within reason. Of course, you're never required to go out and like kill yourself working like a horrible job that you hate just so that they can, like, sit at home all day and, like, eat bags of chips if that's what they prefer to do. I feel like it's a it has to be mutual and. I don't know. I feel like that more or less sums it up for about anything that you could be talking about, whether it's like a family member or like a pet. It's just the effort that you put in. It is the choice to put in that effort, and it is the choice to maybe even absorb some negative consequences for putting in that effort. I would say that, you know, I feel fairly loved or I feel like I'm showing a fair amount of love when I am doing something that may actually negatively impact me later. But for the benefit of the other person, you know that I am performing it for. Like if I stay up all night talking to [Partner's Name] because she's upset about something, even though I have to be up at [Time] to go and work a 12 hour shift, it is something I will do for her usually. Whether or not she asks for it, when she's begging me not to or telling me I really don't have to, I will do it anyway. And I know that she'll do the same for me, so I never feel like it's not reciprocated. Yeah, Just effort.

Speaker 1 [00:23:25] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. And I think you kind of touch on a lot. A bit. But how important is love in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [00:23:36] For me, it's all that matters. I do not want to be with somebody I don't enjoy and somebody that I, you know, don't love. It's obviously not that important to other people. I know plenty of people that get into relationships kind of with the mind of like

a businessman. And if that's what's worked, what's working for them, then that's what's working for them. But for me specifically, I really value it. I do want to love the person I am with and I want them to love me back. And we can you know, I wouldn't say that it's not important for me. Like I do evaluate like a lot of the people that I'm. Considering seeing based on like, Oh, would I run a business with this person. Because if you can't trust them, like with financials reasonably or you couldn't like trust them to make big decisions in your lives, then how are you going to go forth like, you know, running, trying to run a household with them? Like, say, you want kids or even just animals or, you know, just have a shared bank account. If you can't trust them with money, you can have your bank account with them. So I kind of think about that as well. I would not sacrifice romantic feelings like feelings of limerance. For a person that I felt would be really beneficial to be with. However, I would sacrifice. You know, somebody that I was really affectionate towards and felt really good about. If I didn't feel that, you know, I could reasonably, you know, run a business with them as a metaphor. But love is very important.

Speaker 1 [00:25:23] Yeah. And how do you know that your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:25:27] Oh, just because of the effort she puts in, she tells me all the time. I feel like she does not leave much room for speculation. A. Yeah. I mean, she considers my feelings and everything. She apologizes if she does something that upsets me and then does not do it again. She tries all the time to do things that she thinks might make me happy. Um. I feel like that's a pretty good indicator.

Speaker 1 [00:25:56] Yeah, I'd say so. Uh huh. And what would you say are challenges in the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:26:02] My what?

Speaker 1 [00:26:03] What would you say are some challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:26:06] I mean, the distance. I feel a lot of pressure to close the distance. She is in a position in which she has no chance of doing so for the foreseeable future, probably about the next [6-10] years. I'm the one who's mobile, obviously. Currently, I am technically homeless and I hop around. Going to places for work or. You know, like student opportunities that provide housing for free. That's what I'm currently is the [University] in [State] with [Name]. He's the one I live with. And I'm currently here attempting to and I'm I'm going from place to place with the intention of learning as much as I can from these different people and their unique ways of doing things and their unique perspectives. Because eventually I would like to find myself in a situation in which I get to kind of call the shots on where I get to work in a way that makes us both happy because I won't sacrifice my personal enjoyment of like my life and my job to be closer to [Partner's Name]. However, it's something that's in the back of my mind a lot is that I need to, you know, be working to close this distance because I do not foresee a [6-10] year long, long distance relationship working out. In any timeline whatsoever. Of course, I said the thing like where if you want to make it work, you can make it work. But that sort of thing is challenging and I would never ask her to do that. So. I just that's that's probably one of the bigger challenges. I don't feel like we have a lot other than that. We thought that her parents would be a challenge, but they ended up not being as of today. Um, they're just, you know, not, not extremely hostile towards the idea of her dating women, but just, you know. Rather uninterested in engaging with that. But they'll learn. So, yeah, I'm constantly trying to get to a position in which I am able to, you know, and in which people are going to seek me out. To work with them. So either like gaining some notoriety or having a specialized

set of skills will help a lot with that. Because in the meantime, the only thing I can really offer is like lower level work in a barn. Still, with the position of a student, unless, you know, I go to [State], then I'm fairly successful there. But [State] is quite far away from [State]. So I'm constantly working towards that and I feel sometimes as if I don't get it done quickly enough, then things might start to get strained. So it's like some pressure, but, you know, I'm up for it. So it's fine for now.

Speaker 1 [00:29:15] That's good. I'm going to. I'm glad you have hope. Do you and [Partner's Name] fight?

Speaker 2 [00:29:23] I wouldn't say we've ever like. We've never yelled at each other. We've gotten frustrated with one another, usually individually. The other person has no idea. And then, you know, we gather our thoughts and then approach each other very ambivalently. It's never it's never a like, screaming match. Nothing close. It's just like, Hey. I didn't like what you did earlier. I didn't like we said earlier, and it's like, Oh, shit, I didn't realize that upset you. I won't do it again. And then that's the end of it. So I wouldn't say really fight because I thought in a relationship, a fistfight in a relationship before, this is nothing close to that. Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:30:07] How long would you say like this? I know it's like a fight, but how long would you say that normally lasts?

Speaker 2 [00:30:12] It depends on who is confronting him. If I'm telling her I didn't like something she did under 5 minutes. If [Name's] telling me something she doesn't like, it usually takes her anywhere from like an hour to a couple hours to really get her feelings across, because it tends to be a lot of like working through those. Because a lot of the time she doesn't feel like she's allowed to be upset or she feels like it's stupid or, you know, some other excuse to not bring it up, but it's bothering her so she tries to. So we work together to figure out like what exactly is upsetting her, because a lot of times it's a it's like an abstract thought. Like, hey, you said this and it hurt me, but I don't know why or you didn't do this. And it hurt me. And I don't know why. I don't know why I'm still thinking about this. So we work through it to unpack it together, which can take a while. But that's okay. It's really not. It's not a very big deal. I'm. I got plenty of time, so we can sit there for as long as she needs.

Speaker 1 [00:31:16] Yeah. How often would you say? Like this happen. These kind of things happen.

Speaker 2 [00:31:21] Oh, I would say, like, maybe once. [1-5] times a month or [1-5] times every [1-5] months. Really? Not all that often at all since we've been together for since [6-10] months ago when we got together. I can probably count on one hand how many times it's happened. Obviously, but I won't I don't know. I don't really count a lot of like the time in the initial like. Part were, you know, the first couple of months we were together because nobody fights, or at least they shouldn't be in the first couple of months here together because, like, you know, like you're you're probably not going to bring anything up if it bothers you because it hasn't had time to bother you, like in a significant way unless like, unless there's a horrible person on they like killed your dog or something. But, you know, I feel a lot of the things that people have issues with, with one another are habits. Like, I personally will not bring up something that she said if it's like a one off, like, oh, she something came out wrong. Maybe I misunderstood it. I'm going to let it go. However, if it's something that's reoccurring, then I'll be like, All right, you know, maybe it's time to talk about this because this is something that is bothering me frequently, so we need to figure

it out. Otherwise, this is going to be something that grates on me and, you know, will put strain on the relationship. So I don't really count. Like the first probably like [1-5] or [1-5] months. Hello?

Speaker 1 [00:33:11] Yes. Yes.

Speaker 2 [00:33:13] Hello. Sorry about that.

Speaker 1 [00:33:14] No, it's all good. Do you think it would help if I turn off my camera?

Speaker 2 [00:33:18] Probably not. All right. This is just what we're working with right now out in rural [State].

Speaker 1 [00:33:24] Makes sense.

Speaker 2 [00:33:25] Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:33:27] By the way, you looked at that. You said something about [1-5] or [1-5] months. I remembered in my head this time.

Speaker 2 [00:33:31] Well, okay. Yeah, I wouldn't count. Like, the first [1-5] or [1-5] months we were together. Simply because I feel like most people will not have issues in the first couple of months because everything is so new. And, you know, like I said, things haven't had the opposite. Like, you would just haven't had the time to notice habits that bother you. Or if something does bother you, you're way more likely to just write it off because, you know, you're just teeming with so much emotion and so much excitement about this that like, you know, any red flags that you see, they're just you know, you're looking at someone with your road colored glasses. All the red flags are going to look like flags. So you're not going to pay attention, but. Yeah. So just like in the past couple of months, we've had like a couple of issues pop up here and there. Nothing major. Just like, Oh, I didn't like the tone you took with me when you said that. Oh, okay. Sorry. I won't do it again. And then you know you don't, so. Nothing crazy.

Speaker 1 [00:34:26] Yeah. And what are these things like usually about.

Speaker 2 [00:34:29] Oh. Usually like either I don't acknowledge something she said or there was like one issue we had where I felt like she was like being a little too negative towards me. So, you know, I just brought it up and I was like, Hey, I noticed this is something you do a lot and it doesn't make you feel all that good about myself. So can you stop? And she's like, Yeah, I can. I will work on it immediately. And I was like, Okay, perfect. And then when I brought that up, she felt like I was a bit abrasive in the way that I brought it up. And I was like, Oh, that's my bad. You know, That is leftover from the last relationship in which everything was a literal fistfight. I will not take that tone with you again. That was really mean. You are correct. And then I did. So just stuff like that, you know, like minor issues. I'm just like, you know, the diction that you use with each other, sometimes you just aren't quite sure. I'm like, What? What will Somebody off. So it's just about saying, Oh, hey, or I don't like or she specifically has. Like not felt. I don't know like paid attention to in certain ask like very very. Niche things that I didn't do, like when I didn't acknowledge that she wanted to go swimming like really badly. So she was like, Oh yeah, no, I didn't. You know, it would have just been nice if you would have like said sorry, because we didn't go swimming because we just overlooked it. And I was like, Oh, okay, well then, you know, I'll either make sure that we go swimming straight up, make a lake for

you, and a huge plot of land if I need to, to make sure we can go swimming or I will, you know, make sure that I apologize next time. And it's just stuff like that. Literally, like the most minor stuff. And it's resolved really quickly and then it doesn't come back up again. Yeah. You know.

Speaker 1 [00:36:17] That makes sense. Okay, so would you say you. And the result is something like with, like just talking to each other.

Speaker 2 [00:36:23] Yeah. Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:36:25] Let's kind of I was going. I just want to make sure.

Speaker 1 [00:36:28] Oh, awesome.

Speaker 1 [00:36:30] So. What are some This is like another step, but what are some ways that you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:36:39] That. What?

Speaker 1 [00:36:41] That you maintain your relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:36:43] Like, use to maintain the relationship? Um.

Speaker 1 [00:36:49] Like things that you do to maintain the relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:36:52] Oh, yes. Um, I don't know. Like, obviously, since we're a long distance, we call each other quite a bit. That helps. I feel like I use like. And when we're together, I feel like I use a lot of physical touch because I enjoy it and it's fun. I also like to try to come up with ways to, you know, like make her laugh. And I feel like she tries the same with me. Just like little ways to enjoy each other. We'll play games together a lot because you know what? The barrier of long distance that really helps is if you can, like, do an activity online with one another because, you know, topics of conversation are going to slow down. And once you're, you know, you've gotten through like all of your past through like anything that you can bring up that may be funny to think about or talk about. Now all of a sudden, like, all you have to do is talk about like your day to day. And if you had a particularly boring day, if you want to talk to each other for a while or spend some time with each other and you do not have the ability to like. I don't know, like cuddle or have sex or something. This is going to wear on you a little bit because then you're just like sitting in silence. So what we'll do is we'll watch a lot of movies or play like little online games with one another. That always helps.

Speaker 1 [00:38:14] Yeah, that sounds like a really great way to maintain your relationship out with, like, this long distance. So it sounds really good. And would you say that the relationship is good for you and why?

Speaker 2 [00:38:29] Oh, yeah, I think it's good for me. For me specifically, because. She helps to I don't know. It's going to sound so corny, but she has to push me to be like a little bit better because, you know, she is getting a literal [educational attainment]. I am getting no such thing. Don't know if you noticed. I'm a little bit of a dumb ass. She also be just a little bit less of a dumb ass. Obviously she can't cure me. However, her effort, whether intentional or not, is helping a lot. So. I don't know. I'm not interested in any higher education or anything, but I feel like being around her has helped me, like, especially when

I've gone through issues with the current career path I have chosen, which is, you know, working with [occupation], specifically specializing in [specialization], which is a very lucrative career, if you can manage to get into it properly. Thankfully, I'm with the best in the business. You wouldn't be able to tell because he's an asshole and he does not do marketing very well. I love him to death though. He is definitely a pioneer of his time and a borderline genius with what he's doing. There was a time in which I didn't know if I wanted to do this anymore and I was kind of just considering throwing in the towel because, you know, this work is hard and it takes a lot of grit to work with horses because they are not cute animals. Especially when you're in the position of training them. They are assholes. But, you know, feeling the need to keep up with her in a way does help me from just, you know, deciding to stagnate and throw in the towel. Not that I think I could anyway, but it's it helps to have that little bit of push there.

Speaker 1 [00:40:31] Yeah, that makes sense. Also, I want to say. I think you sound really intelligent to me, but I think you sounded really smart. So to everything where you said the communication earlier, I was like, Wow, that was like spot on.

Speaker 2 [00:40:48] You're just buttering me up so you can Get to that personal information you were talking about.

Speaker 1 [00:40:53] Exactly.

Speaker 2 [00:40:54] What do you need that in a meeting?

Speaker 1 [00:40:58] I'm going to see that. I'm saying you can see right through me. This is this is this is the intelligence coming right through.

Speaker 2 [00:41:04] Oh, no, no. That was the pact I made with the with the devil so I can read minds.

Speaker 1 [00:41:13] Makes sense. Anyways, the next question is did the relationship change you and in what way? And I think you can touched on this before, but I'm more specific.

Speaker 2 [00:41:22] Oh, I mean, yeah, it definitely changed me. I would say it brought out like the better things about me. And also it has helped me like be less on guard and less immediately confrontational with people. I am on an asshole. I am mean. I am known for making people cry. Not everybody! I'm very patient with like, you know, a lot of people. But, you know, if I perceive somebody as, you know, like an opponent, then, like, all bets are off. I'm fairly known for this. I've had a lot of issues in past workplaces because of this and literally gotten fired because of, you know. Being very combative with a coworker that I did not respect. And this kind of. Is something that has popped up in past, like romantic relationships, because when there's so much emotion involved, yeah, there's going to be a lot of good emotion involved. But that's very, you know, the strong and intense feeling that you get. It's extremely easy to cross over into feelings of like disdain or defensiveness, which is what I used to experience a lot. So what she has had to address with me before where it's like, hey, you didn't need to get like so, you know, so immediately on the offense because, you know, the best defense is a good offense is what I'm always saying. So if you just attack them first, then fine. Like I was never super mean to her, but the tone I took was not, you know, it just it wasn't necessary. So she helped me realize that I don't need to be like that. I'm a lot less worried about just, you know, existing because in a past relationship, I was not allowed to basically enjoy myself or my life. It was just a hostile

environment. I wasn't allowed to, like, do anything new. I wasn't really allowed to better myself because, you know, it was a threat to him. She's made me realize that's not something I need to feel anymore. So there's been a lot of rerouting there. I feel like I'm just overall in better shape and less on the defense all the time or on the offense, you know, in my case and feeling like I constantly need to, you know, be ready for a fight because it's just not necessary.

Speaker 1 [00:43:47] Yeah. Yeah. And what about [Partner's Name]? Do you think she changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:43:52] Yeah, I think she's gotten. I think she's gone in the opposite direction where she's gotten a little bit better at standing up for herself. One of the things that I've begged her to do, basically, is if you have a problem with something I do, please tell me I will not get mad at you. I am always interested in at least hearing you out, even if I don't agree. And we can still talk it out because I feel like there's always a middle ground. Like if something is bothering you enough to where you know you're thinking about it a lot, your emotions are telling you that for a reason. That's what emotions are there for. Ignoring them is not. It's you shouldn't be doing that. Whether or not you think they're stupid, they're there for a reason. Um, so I've tried really hard to help her out with becoming more comfortable with, you know, like confrontation in general, because I obviously have no problem with it. Um, and one of the things like, I know I've made myself sound like a little bit like the devil, but one of the things I do push a lot is that confrontation does not have to be scary or combative. You can confront somebody in a way that honestly doesn't even like bring down the mood of the situation. I do it all the time and I feel like, you know, just pushing that has helped her a lot. She is a lot better about bringing things up, even if it takes her a while, even if so, that she's like, you know, she has to like, get through it, basically kicking and screaming, you know, dragging herself along to try and get these thoughts across. She still does it, which is good because she was scared at the beginning that she just simply would not bring these up at all. And I was like, can't do that. I won't let you do that.

Speaker 1 [00:45:30] Yeah, it's it's like, I mean, you guys changed for the better. So I think it's really great. Mm hmm. Um, so my question is about safety, so. Um, I think you've kind of already touched on this, but do you feel safe in the relationship? And why would you say so?

Speaker 2 [00:45:48] Oh, I mean, for sure. I mean, [Partner's Name] does not pose a threat. I do not like. She's just definitely not out to get me. There is no bitterness there. I don't feel like obviously there's always the threat of like, oh, you know what? If she decides she wants to leave one day? But I don't go into relationships with the fear that, like, someone will leave. And I'm like, feeling like I need to be the one to, you know, prevent that. I feel like we can enjoy our time together, whether she lives in the future or not, or whether I decide to end the relationship in the future or not. We're having a good time now and that is not like sullied or made. Obsolete because it may end one day. So I feel rather secure. She obviously just isn't like a manipulative person or somebody who's going to like wake up one day and decide that she wants to, like, smack me around. And if she did not going to lie, I don't think she'd be hard to fight. So we're all good over here.

Speaker 1 [00:46:56] Yeah. Yeah. Can you provide any examples of, like, times you felt like safe in the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:47:02] Oh, I mean, she's just pretty good at, like. Not making me feel bad about things that, you know, I may be more inclined to hide because they're embarrassing. A. So, yeah, I don't know. She's just never given me a reason to feel unsafe.

Speaker 1 [00:47:21] Yeah. Makes sense.

Speaker 2 [00:47:22] Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:47:23] Okay, so the next part of this interview is going to talk about, like, partner responsiveness. And I'm going to. I don't know. I'm going to share my screen. Hold on. Okay. So I'm going to ask you this question. Right. What that's a spoiler. Sorry. I'm going to ask you a question and then you're going to tell me like what number on the scale you think you are. And I'm going to ask you, like, why? So yeah. So the first question is my partner usually really listens to me. So like, what number do you think you'd be on the scale?

Speaker 2 [00:48:10] Hello? Hello? Hello. Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:48:14] I'm so sorry. Okay. Did you. Do you. Did you did you hear any of, like, the direction I just gave?

Speaker 2 [00:48:22] Nope.

Speaker 1 [00:48:22] Awesome. Okay. Basically, um. I'm going to provide you like a scale and then I'm going to ask you a question I'm going to ask and then I'm going to ask you after you enter your number to the question why you answered that number, if that makes sense.

Speaker 2 [00:48:39] Okay. Sounds good.

Speaker 1 [00:48:40] Okay. Awesome.

Speaker 2 [00:48:41] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:48:43] So the first question is, my partner usually really listens to me.

Speaker 2 [00:48:47] Yeah, I would say that that's like a nine. Completely true.

Speaker 1 [00:48:52] Okay, Why would you say that? It's not like eight. Or seven.

Speaker 2 [00:48:57] Because she just does. I tell her something. She. She listens to it. Sometimes a little too well, and I just it's just fine. She's just never given me a reason to feel like. I mean, like, maybe if she's, like, distracted or something, but I wouldn't feel like that really applies to this question. I feel like it's more about like, you know. Like emotional needs and stuff like that. And she's never the type to, you know, write that shit off or tell me it's like ridiculous or anything like that. So there's just no reason to feel otherwise.

Speaker 1 [00:49:36] All right, great. And what about this question? My partner usually is responsive to my needs.

Speaker 2 [00:49:42] Oh, yeah, I think so. Nine, obviously, for the same reasons. The last question, she just never has proven herself to not be. We have restrictions because of

what we can do for one another, but within, you know, our capabilities. I feel like she's perfectly fine with trying to respond to and fulfill needs.

Speaker 1 [00:50:06] Okay, great. And then how satisfied are you with your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:50:11] Oh, I'm pretty satisfied. I would say like very satisfied. Completely satisfied, you know?

Speaker 1 [00:50:19] Somewhere along those lines. Okay, let me see. See, I like. I think this like provides a better scale. Like from 1 to 10. How would you rate your satisfaction in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:50:27] I feel like an eight.

Speaker 1 [00:50:29] An eight. Okay, Why would you say that instead of like, a seven or nine?

Speaker 2 [00:50:32] Oh. I mean, because I'm fairly like, I'm satisfied with, like, the connection we have with each other, the way that we work with one another. It's just, you know, the distance isn't ideal, but that's all.

Speaker 1 [00:50:46] Yeah. Okay. Yeah, that's totally makes sense. So. But. That clarifies it also. That was it with that little spiel.

Speaker 1 [00:50:54] Of.

Speaker 1 [00:50:55] Scales. All right. Thank you for doing that. And then this is the personal question that you're super excited for.

Speaker 1 [00:51:05] I know, right?

Speaker 1 [00:51:06] I know. I know. It's actually not that personal, just about sex. So it's like, I don't know. But anyways, so these days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker 1 [00:51:15] That's the first question. No. Hello? Hello? Sorry.

Speaker 1 [00:51:36] It's okay. It's okay. Where did we leave off? Okay. I think.

Speaker 2 [00:51:40] Personal question. Okay. Personally, I didn't hear any of it.

Speaker 1 [00:51:43] Okay, so the. The personal questions are just about sex. So these days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker 2 [00:51:52] Oh. Oh. Like when we're together or overall.

Speaker 1 [00:52:08] I would say when you're together.

Speaker 2 [00:52:11] Oh, often. Like at least every other night, usually. Sometimes not..

Speaker 1 [00:52:21] Okay. And how satisfied are you with your sex life? And why would you say so?

Speaker 2 [00:52:25] Oh, I'm pretty satisfied.

Speaker 1 [00:52:29] And do you mind saying, why?

Speaker 2 [00:52:33] I mean, I just I am not like a person with a super high sex drive. And I feel like she's not the type. I mean, she hasn't done any, like, pressuring or anything or making me, like, feel bad for not being the type to have a high sex drive. But, you know, I feel like not being together all the time takes a lot of pressure off of me to feel like I need to do it whether I want to or not. So honestly, the fact that we have some distance between us is kind of ideal for that specifically. Like, it's not like I want to keep it there for that reason, but you know, it helps with just not feeling like, Oh my God, are we going to tonight? Do I need to? Oh, my God, has it been too long or something? Because, you know, by the time we're allowed to be together there again, I'm usually, like, in the mood again. It's fine. Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:53:22] Okay. That makes sense. Okay. Thank you for. Those were the only two personal questions I know. What was that personal I think for you, maybe. But.

Speaker 1 [00:53:32] Um. Yeah. Um.

Speaker 1 [00:53:35] So that actually summarizes, like, the the bulk of the interview. So we are kind of close wrapping up. So I would like to summarize what we've conversed about in the past. 50 ish minutes. So it sounds to me like you have a pretty high satisfaction in your relationship and the main. Thing that is hindering your satisfaction is like long distance and being in different fields of like careers and being like, in different places and. Um, yeah. You think a good relationship is good for you in that you both have changed for the better? Is that an accurate depiction of what you think and would like? Is anything you'd like to add?

Speaker 2 [00:54:27] No. I feel like that's fine.

Speaker 1 [00:54:29] Okay. Awesome. Okay. Um, so before we end, I want to talk to you about how we're going to handle the data as a research project. We want to be as ethically transparent as possible. And so I want to know which data sharing option you are most comfortable with. So the option one is that the transcript portions can be shared, none of which can be identified to you. So the data, the de-identified transcript can also be read by other researchers. So anything that like traces you back to like you would be like removed. And then option two is if you're bolder. Another option is that the whole transcript can be shared. And it will be removed of sensitive and overly identifying details so will be anonymized. Although in this option there is very minimal chance that someone who knows you well can piece together the details in the transcript and narrow down who among their colleagues they believe it is. Although again, no sensitive information will be shared. So of the two options, which are you more comfortable with?

Speaker 2 [00:55:41] Oh, whichever one you want. You can fucking attach my social media to it if you want a whole ass selfie of me. Like I said, Social security number. I don't give a shit. Use as much or as little of it as you want and give anybody any information about me that they desire. I do not care. It's not my priority.

Speaker 1 [00:56:02] I kind of relate to that a lot. I really should care more about that. My dad is always so stressed about me. I mean, anyways, that's a different.

Speaker 1 [00:56:12] Topic.

Speaker 1 [00:56:13] Altogether, but yes. Okay. Sounds good. So, okay, so we're going to thank you again so much for participating in the study. So the way that the study works is we are using snowball sampling, which I'll explain to you, is called in. Basically, it's like you when you interview someone and you ask them for other people to interview and then interview them, they ask more people interview. So you get more and more people to interview, if that makes sense. So it's like this sort of like it rolling on the Hill. So basically this last question is basically like if you know any other couples or. Non-monogamous relationships.

Speaker 1 [00:57:02] Or.

Speaker 1 [00:57:04] Yeah. I feel like I know anyone who is in a relationship or if you know anyone who might know someone like some other people who are in a relationship that you can nominate and. Like as a contact for me to to reach out so I can interview them. How that makes sense. Does it?

Speaker 2 [00:57:20] Yeah, unfortunately, I know like a couple, but none of them are. Nobody I know is going to want to do this. I'm sorry There's not interested in participating in stuff like this.

Speaker 1 [00:57:32] But no, that is honestly completely valid. Especially since we are not providing any financial compensation, so that's obviously very valid. Do you happen to know anyone who would know anyone else who might be interested if not that's totally fine too? But I just have to ask.

Speaker 2 [00:57:49] Oh. I mean, potentially I could point you in the direction of a friend that I have. She might know some people because she went to college and she has other friends who are like currently in college who are in the LGBT community. I don't know, what do you want me to do? Do you want me to give her? Do you want me to, like, have [Partner's Name] send you, like, a link to her, like Facebook or something, and you can message her and I'll tell her you're messaging her.

Speaker 1 [00:58:15] Yeah, that would be. That would be really great if you could do that.

Speaker 2 [00:58:19] Okay, Just remind [Partner's Name] because I will forget. And you know, it's just a chain. Just just text her and I'll be and I'll. I'll remember. It's good. I'll hook you up.

Speaker 1 [00:58:27] Sounds good. It sounds good.

Speaker 2 [00:58:29] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:58:30] Awesome. Awesome. Okay, awesome. Okay. That was it. Thank you so much again for doing this. Really means a lot. Thank you for taking the time and I really appreciated learning, but that was a very interesting interview. I really appreciated it so well.

Speaker 2 [00:58:44] Thanks so much. I'm glad you had fun

Speaker 1 [00:58:47] Okay. Have fun later.

Speaker 2 [00:58:49] Bye. Bye. See You.